MODULE 28 · DOMAIN 6 - STAKEHOLDER COMMUNICATION AND LIFECYCLE

Feedback, Expectations and SLAs

SLA anatomy and the SLO beneath it, quality as a service level, baselines before promises, honest renegotiation, scope change, and feedback sessions that produce decisions.

DOMAIN 6 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 14% MODULE 28 of 38

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"Within five minutes, measured over four weeks, compensation if missed." **A promise without a window and a consequence is a hope.**

Anatomy of an SLA

PART	WHAT IT FIXES	QUILLON PORTAL
Metric	What is measured	Time to first token
Threshold	The level, with a percentile	Within 2 s at p95
Window	The period it is judged over	Each calendar month
Scope	What is in and out	Portal questions; planned maintenance out
Measurement	Who measures, where	Gateway logs, shared dashboard
Breach consequence	What happens if missed	Service credit and fix plan

THE TIEBREAKER

Metric, threshold, window, scope, measurement, consequence. Missing one makes it unenforceable.

Quirk 12: "The assistant shall be fast"

FIRST DRAFT

Quillon portal contract

```
1 The assistant shall be fast
2 and reliable.
```

No metric, no level, no window, nothing to breach.

REWRITTEN

Quillon portal contract

```
1 Time to first token for portal
2 questions: within 2 s at p95,
3 per calendar month, from gateway
4 logs. Correct on at least 92% of
5 the agreed evaluation set, re-run
6 monthly. Breach: service credit
7 and a fix plan within 10 days.
```

Speed and quality, each measurable and enforceable.

THE TIEBREAKER

Turn every adjective into a metric, a threshold, a window and a consequence.

SLI, SLO, SLA and the error budget

TERM	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE
SLI	The measured indicator	p95 time to first token
SLO	Internal target, stricter than the SLA	1.5 s at p95
SLA	External promise with consequences	2 s at p95
Error budget	Failure the SLO allows	Spent: pause changes, fix reliability

THE TIEBREAKER

Run to the SLO, promise the SLA. The gap between them is your warning time.

What is different about SLAs for Claude systems

- **Quality is a service level:** an accuracy floor on an agreed evaluation set, re-run on a schedule.
- **Latency depends on output length:** state first token, total time, or both.
- **Model versions change:** re-run the evaluation set before any switch.
- **Rate limits are capacity:** size them for peak, not average.
- **Upstream availability caps your promise,** unless you design fallbacks.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A fast wrong answer meets a latency SLA and fails the customer. Put quality in the agreement.

Your SLA sits on Claude's availability

- **Standard tier:** the default, with "best-effort availability".
- **Priority Tier** targets 99.5% uptime, but new commitments are no longer sold.
- **Every response** reports the tier used, in **usage.service_tier**.
- **So design for failure:** retries with backoff, graceful degradation, a human path.
- **Promise the service,** including its degraded mode, not the model call.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Never promise more availability than your dependencies give, unless the design covers the gap.

Baselines before promises

- **Measure p50 and p95** on representative pilot traffic, at realistic volume.
- **Measure today's process too:** the human baseline you are improving on.
- **Share ranges, not a single best number** from a demo.
- **Set the threshold with margin** below what you measured.
- **Never promise** from a demo, a vendor figure, or a sales deadline.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Every expectation conversation starts with a measured number.

Renegotiating honestly

01
Detect early
The SLO burns before the SLA breaks.

02
Quantify
The gap, with measured data.

03
Explain
The cause, plainly.

04
Offer options
Relax, invest, or descope.

05
Agree
In writing, with the owner.

06
Record
Update the SLA and the ADR.

ON THE EXAM

Raise it when the objective burns, not after the agreement breaks. Never hide the gap.

Scope change: acknowledge, state impact, offer options

STEP	MERESIDE ADDS POSTED LETTERS
Acknowledge	A sensible extension of triage
State impact	Vision, new eval set, later launch, more cost
Option 1	Add now, move the launch date
Option 2	Email first; letters in phase two
Option 3	Letters for one complaint type
Decide, record	Sponsor chooses; change log records it

THE TIEBREAKER

Never absorb scope silently, or refuse it flatly. Show the trade-off; the owner chooses.

Feedback sessions that produce decisions

- **Agenda from data:** metrics, sampled outputs, complaints, incidents.
- **Decisions listed in advance,** so the right owners attend.
- **Users and owners in the room,** not only the project team.
- **Every item ends** with a decision, an owner and a date.
- **Feedback becomes test cases:** failures join the evaluation set.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If a feedback session changes nothing, it was a status meeting.

A cadence that matches the risk

CADENCE	FORUM	LOOKS AT
Continuous	Alerts	Error budget burn, failures, cost spikes
Weekly	Operations review	Sampled outputs, incidents, open fixes
Monthly	Feedback session with owner	SLA report, quality, user feedback, decisions
Quarterly	Steering review	Roadmap, model changes, renegotiation

THE TIEBREAKER

Faster loops for operations, slower loops for direction. Each loop has an owner.

Reconciling stakeholders who want different things

- **Surface the conflict** explicitly; do not average it away.
- **Trace each wish** to the goal and the person behind it.
- **Quantify the trade-off** with real outputs and measurements.
- **Take it to the decision owner,** with options and a recommendation.
- **Record the decision,** and tell everyone why.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The decision owner resolves conflicts. The architect makes the trade-off visible.

> Quillon's portal contract draft says the assistant "shall be fast and reliable".
>
> Legal asks Corvane to make the clause enforceable.

Which rewrite should Corvane propose?

A. Average response time under two seconds, measured continuously across all traffic

B. As fast as technically possible, with best efforts to stay reliable at all times

C. Ninety-nine point nine nine percent uptime, matching a major cloud provider's published availability figure

D. First token within two seconds at the ninety-fifth percentile, monthly, from gateway logs, with a breach consequence

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which rewrite should Corvane propose?

A. Average response time under two seconds, measured continuously across all traffic
An average hides the slow tail.

B. As fast as technically possible, with best efforts to stay reliable at all times
Still nothing measurable to breach.

C. Ninety-nine point nine nine percent uptime, matching a major cloud provider's published availability figure
Borrowed, unmeasured, and not this system.

D. First token within two seconds at the ninety-fifth percentile, monthly, from gateway logs, with a breach consequence
Metric, threshold, window, source, consequence.

THE SIGNAL

An enforceable SLA has a metric, a percentile threshold, a window, a measurement source and a consequence.

> Tallyhawk's sales team wants to promise enterprise customers in-app answers "in under one second".
>
> The pilot starts next week. Nothing has been measured yet.

What should Corvane advise?

A. Measure the median and ninety-fifth percentile on representative pilot traffic, then set a threshold with margin

B. Promise one second now, and tune the system to meet it during the pilot

C. Use the fastest timing seen in last month's demo as the promise

D. Quote the model's published speed figures as the customer promise

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane advise?

A. Measure the median and ninety-fifth percentile on representative pilot traffic, then set a threshold with margin
A promise built on a baseline.

B. Promise one second now, and tune the system to meet it during the pilot
Promise first, measure later breaks trust.

C. Use the fastest timing seen in last month's demo as the promise
A demo is the best case, not the tail.

D. Quote the model's published speed figures as the customer promise
Model speed is not system latency.

THE SIGNAL

Every expectation starts from a measured baseline on representative traffic.

> Tallyhawk's enterprise customers want a very high availability commitment for the support agent.
>
> It runs on the Claude API's standard tier, with no fallback today.

What should Corvane recommend?

A Commit to the figure, since the Claude API has rarely been unavailable and incidents are short

B Commit, but exclude every upstream outage from the measurement quietly

C Design retries, graceful degradation and a human path, then commit to the service level that design supports

D Refuse any availability commitment at all, because the model is outside Tallyhawk's control

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane recommend?

A Commit to the figure, since the Claude API has rarely been unavailable and incidents are short

Rarely is not a design.

B Commit, but exclude every upstream outage from the measurement quietly

A hidden exclusion destroys trust.

C Design retries, graceful degradation and a human path, then commit to the service level that design supports

Promise what the design delivers.

D Refuse any availability commitment at all, because the model is outside Tallyhawk's control

Over-corrects. Design for it instead.

THE SIGNAL

Never promise more availability than your dependencies give, unless the design covers the gap.

> Quillon added insurance-coverage lookups to the portal.
>
> The portal's p95 first token is now 2.6 seconds against a 2 second SLA. The average is still 1.4 seconds.

What should Corvane do?

A Report the average instead, since it is comfortably within the target

B Bring the measured gap and its cause to Quillon, with options, and agree a change in writing

C Exclude coverage questions from the measurement until they are faster

D Switch every portal question to the smallest model tier to recover speed

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do?

A Report the average instead, since it is comfortably within the target

Changing the metric hides the breach.

B Bring the measured gap and its cause to Quillon, with options, and agree a change in writing

Honest renegotiation, with options.

C Exclude coverage questions from the measurement until they are faster

A quiet exclusion is still hiding it.

D Switch every portal question to the smallest model tier to recover speed

May break the 92% quality floor.

THE SIGNAL

Renegotiate with data and options. Never change what you measure to hide a gap.

> Mid-build, Mereside's head of complaints asks Corvane to add posted letters to complaints triage.
>
> The launch date is fixed in the plan.

How should Corvane respond?

A. Acknowledge it, state the impact on date, cost and testing, and offer options for the sponsor to choose

B. Absorb it quietly, and have the team work longer hours to keep the fixed launch date

C. Decline firmly, because the scope was signed off weeks ago and changes need a new contract

D. Add letters, and shorten evaluation to protect the launch date

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should Corvane respond?

A Acknowledge it, state the impact on date, cost and testing, and offer options for the sponsor to choose

Acknowledge, impact, options, owner decides.

B Absorb it quietly, and have the team work longer hours to keep the fixed launch date

Hidden cost, and the date slips anyway.

C Decline firmly, because the scope was signed off weeks ago and changes need a new contract

A flat refusal ignores a sensible request.

D Add letters, and shorten evaluation to protect the launch date

Trades quality for a date, silently.

THE SIGNAL

Scope change: acknowledge, state impact, offer options, let the sponsor decide.

> Tallyhawk's monthly feedback meeting runs ninety minutes. Everyone shares opinions about the support agent.
>
> Three months on, nothing has changed.

What should Corvane change?

A Meet weekly instead of monthly, so problems are discussed sooner and in more depth

B Replace the meeting with an anonymous survey of support staff and product managers

C Invite more stakeholders from across the business, so every view is heard first

D Build the agenda from data, list decisions in advance, and end each item with an owner, a date and new test cases

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane change?

A Meet weekly instead of monthly, so problems are discussed sooner and in more depth

More of a meeting that decides nothing.

B Replace the meeting with an anonymous survey of support staff and product managers

Collects opinions, decides nothing.

C Invite more stakeholders from across the business, so every view is heard first

More opinions, still no decisions.

D Build the agenda from data, list decisions in advance, and end each item with an owner, a date and new test cases

Data in, decisions and test cases out.

THE SIGNAL

Feedback sessions are judged by the decisions they produce.

> Quillon clinicians want longer, detailed discharge summaries. Ward managers want them much shorter.
>
> Both groups are pressing Corvane to change the prompt their way.

Which two actions should Corvane take? Choose two.

- A Trace each preference to the goal behind it, and who owns that goal
- B Set the length halfway between the two requests
- C Quantify the trade-off with real summaries, and take options to the decision owner
- D Follow whichever group escalates most senior
- E Build two versions quietly, and let each ward pick

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two actions should Corvane take? Choose two.

A Trace each preference to the goal behind it, and who owns that goal

Finds the real goals.

B Set the length halfway between the two requests

Averaging satisfies nobody.

C Quantify the trade-off with real summaries, and take options to the decision owner

Visible trade-off, owner decides.

D Follow whichever group escalates most senior

Seniority is not the decision process.

E Build two versions quietly, and let each ward pick

Splits the system without a decision.

THE SIGNAL

The architect makes the trade-off visible. The decision owner resolves it.

In five lines

- **SLA anatomy:** metric, percentile threshold, window, scope, measurement, consequence.
- **Run to the SLO,** promise the SLA; put quality in the agreement.
- **Baselines first;** never promise beyond your dependencies without fallbacks.
- **Renegotiate with data;** scope change gets impact and options.
- **Feedback sessions** end in decisions, owners, dates and test cases.

COMING UP

Next: documentation, handoff and the lifecycle.